Important Update

2026-09-14 00:00:00

On September 14, 2026, the U.S. District Court for the District of Massachusetts issued an order pausing the effective date of the Department of Homeland Security's Duration of Status Final Rule while litigation concerning the rule continues.

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Optional Practical Training (OPT)

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What Is Optional Practical Training?

Optional Practical Training (OPT) is a type of work authorization that permits F-1 students to gain work experience in their field of study while in the United States. OPT is an optional employment benefit offered to F-1 students who maintain their visa statuses — it is not a separate visa category.

Students must first obtain an OPT recommendation I-20 from OIS before submitting their OPT application and supporting documents to the U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) for adjudication.

There are three types of OPT. Please review th

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Pre-Completion OPT

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STEM OPT Extension

The STEM OPT Extension is an additional 24 months of work authorization for students who are in an approved period of Post-Completion OPT and have a degree in one of the Science, Technology, Engineering and Math (STEM) majors on the STEM Designated Degree Program list provided by the U.S. Department of Homeland Security. Please visit our STEM OPT Extension page for additional information.

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Related Pages

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STEM OPT Extension

STEM OPT Extension Based on a Prior Degree

Gap Extension

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